Short Stories (from The Pillowman)

By Martin McDonagh

INTRODUCTION

Martin McDonagh's play The Pillowman is about a writer who is interrogated about the gruesome content of his short stories and their similarities to a number of child-murders that are happening in his town. He learns that his older brother, Michal, is also being held and questioned in another cell. Michal, who has the mind of a child. Michal, who our author, Katurian, has raised ever since the death of their parents.

The first short story tells the tale of Katurian and Michal – it is believed to be somewhat autobiographical . . . right up until the end. The Writer and the Writer's Brother by Martin McDonagh writing as Katurian Katurian,

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Once upon a time there was a little boy upon whom his mother and father showered nothing but love, kindness, warmth, all that stuff. He had his own little room in a big house in the middle of a pretty forest. He

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wanted for nothing: all the toys in the world were his; all the paints, all the books, paper, pens. All the seeds of creativity were implanted in him from an early age and it was writing that became his first love: short stories, fairy tales, little novels, all happy colorful things about bears and piglets and angels and so forth, and some of them were good, some of them were very good. His parents' experiment had worked.

It was the night of his seventh birthday that the nightmares first started. The room next door to his own room had always been kept bolted and padlocked for reasons the boy was never quite sure of but never quite questioned until the low whirring of drills, the scritchety-scratch of bolts being tightened, the dull fizz of unknown things electrical, and the muffled screams of a small gagged child began to emanate through its thick brick walls. On a nightly basis.

CHILD'S VOICE: (to mother) What were all those noises last night, Mama?

He'd ask, after each long, desperate, sleepless night, to which his mother would ever reply . . .

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MOTHER: Oh, that's just your wonderful but overactive imagination playing tricks on you.

CHILD'S VOICE: Oh. Do all little boys of my age hear such sounds of abomination nightly?

MOTHER: No, my darling. Only the extraordinarily talented ones.

CHILD'S VOICE: Oh. Cool.

And that was that. And the boy kept on writing, and his parents kept encouraging him with the utmost love, but the sounds of the whirrs and screams kept going on . . . and his stories got darker and darker and darker. They got better and better, due to all of the love and encouragement, as is often the case, but they got darker and darker, due to the constant sound of child-torture, as is also often the case.

It was on the day of his fourteenth birthday, a day he was waiting to hear the results of a story competition he was short-listed for, that a note slipped out from under the door of the locked room . . . *(a note in red writing slips under the door and the speaker picks it up)* . . . a note which read: 'They have loved you and

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tortured me for seven straight years for no reason other than as an artistic experiment, an artistic experiment which has worked. You don't write about little green pigs any more, do you?' The note was signed 'Your brother', and the note was written in blood.

He axed through the door to find . . . his parents sitting in there, smiling, alone; his father doing some drill noises; his mother doing some muffled screams of a gagged child; they had a little pot of pig's blood between them, and his father told him to look at the other side of the blood-written note. The boy did, and found out he'd won the fifty-pounds first prize in the short-story competition. They all laughed. The second part of his parents' experiment was complete.

They moved house soon after that and though the nightmare sounds had ended, his stories stayed strange and twisted but good, and he was able to thank his parents for the weirdness they'd put him through, and years later, on the day that his first book was published, he decided to revisit his childhood home for the first time since he'd left. He idled around his old

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bedroom, and all the toys and paints still littered around there . . . then he went into the room beside it that still had the old dusty drills and padlocks and electrical cord lying around, and he smiled at the insanity of the very idea of it all, but he lost his smile when he came across . . . *(He pulls the mattress of to reveal the horrific corpse of a child)* the corpse of a fourteen-year-old child that had been left to rot in there, barely a bone of which wasn't broken or burned, in whose hand there lay a story, scrawled in blood. And the boy read that story, a story that could only have been written under the most sickening of circumstances, and it was the sweetest, gentlest thing he'd ever come across, but what was even worse, it was better than anything he himself had ever written Or ever would *(Speaker takes a lighter and sets the story alight).* So he burnt the story, and he covered his brother back up, and he never mentioned a word of what he had seen to anybody. Not to his parents, not to his publishers, not to anybody. The final part of his parents' experiment was over. '

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Katurian's story 'The Writer and the Writer's Brother' ended there in a fashionably downbeat mode, without touching upon the equally downbeat but somewhat more self-incriminating details of the truer story, that after he'd read the blood-written note and broken into the next-door room it was, of course . . . his brother he found in there, alive, as such, but brain-damaged beyond repair, and that night, whilst his parents were sleeping, the fourteen-year-old birthday boy held a pillow over his father's head for a little while . . . and, after waking her a moment just to let her see her dead blue husband, he held a pillow over his mother's head for a little while too.

TRANSITION

After the deaths of Katurian and Michal's parents, Katurian becomes the sole care-giver for his brother Michal, regaling him every night with stories he has written – dark stories.

As Martin McDonagh's play The Pillowman opens, we find out that both brain-damaged Michal and our author, Katurian, have been arrested for the gruesome murders of 2 local children. A third little girl has now been reported missing. Strangely enough, each murdered child was put to death in a manner described in one of Katurian's short stories: the removal of toes, the swallowing of razor blades.

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The third little girl, however, has yet to be found; and as the play progresses, Michal claims responsibility and explains that 'The Little Jesus' was the inspiration for her disappearance.

The Little Jesus by Martin McDonagh writing as Katurian Katurian

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Once upon a time in a land not so very far away there lived a little girl, and although this little girl's gentle parents hadn't brought her up very religiously at all, she was quite, quite determined that she was the second coming of the Lord Jesus Christ.

Which was somewhat strange for any six-year-old. She'd wear a little beard and would go around in sandals, blessing stuff. She could be forever found walking amongst the poor and the homeless, consoling the drunks and the drug addicts, and generally consorting with the type of person her mummy and daddy didn't deem suitable for a six-year-old to be consorting with. Each time they would drag her home from some unsavory sort, she would stamp and scream

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and throw her dollies about, and when her parents would counter that . . .

MOM OR DAD: Jesus never stamped and screamed and threw his dollies about . . .

She'd reply . . .

LITTLE GIRL: That was the old Jesus! Get it?

Well, one day, the little girl slipped away yet again, and for two horrifying days her parents could find neither hide nor hair of her, until they received a distraught call from a priest they didn't know saying:

PRIEST: You'd better come down to the church. Your daughter's here giving us a lot of shit. It was cute at first, but now it's really getting irritating.

Well, her parents didn't care about all that, they were just relieved that she was alive and well, and they sped downtown to pick her up, but in their haste they careened into an oncoming meat truck, were beheaded and died.

The little girl was informed of the news; she cried one single tear, and not a single tear more, as she

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thought Jesus would've done if he'd lost his parents in a vehicular beheading; and she was shipped off by the state to live in a forest with some abusive foster-parents . . . who hadn't informed the state that they were abusive on the form; who hated religion, who hated Jesus, who hated anybody, in fact, who didn't hate anybody, and who, as would follow, hated the little girl.

She bore their hate with a happy heart and forgave them, but this didn't seem to work. When she insisted on attending church of a Sunday, they took her sandals away, forcing her to walk there barefoot and alone, over craggy roads of broken glass, yet when she got there, she'd kneel for hours, praying for her Father in Heaven to forgive them, only to get told off for bleeding all over the church. She'd receive a beating for arriving late home, though no time had been set for her arrival; she'd receive a beating for sharing her food with the poor children at school; she'd receive a beating for cheering up the ugly kids; she'd receive a beating for wandering about looking for lepers. Her life was a constant torture, yet she bore it with a smile and it all

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only made her stronger, till this one day when she met a blind man begging by the roadside.

She mixed a little of her spittle in the dust and rubbed it over his eyes. He reported her to the police for rubbing dust and spittle in his eyes, and when her foster-parents got her back from the police station they said to her . . .

MOM OR DAD: So you want to be just like Jesus, do you?

And she said . .

LITTLE GIRL: Finally, you get it!

Her foster mother embedded in her daughter's head a crown of thorns made of barbed wire, because she was too lazy to make a proper crown of thorns, while her foster-father whipped her with a cat o'nine tails, and after an hour or two of that, they asked her, when she regained consciousness

MOM OR DAD: Do you still want to be like Jesus?

And, through her tears, she said

LITTLE GIRL: Yes, I do.

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So they made her carry a heavy wooden cross around the sitting room a hundred times until her legs buckled and her shins broke and she could do nothing but stare at her little legs going the wrong way, and they said to her . . .

MOM OR DAD: Do you still want to be like Jesus?

And she almost got sick for a second, but she swallowed it so she wouldn't look weak and she looked them in the eye and she said . . .

LITTLE GIRL: Yes, I do

And then they nailed her hands to the cross and bent her legs back around the right way and nailed her feet to the cross and they stood the cross up against the back wall and left her there while they watched television, and when all the good programs were over, they turned it off and they sharpened a spear and they said to her.

MOM OR DAD; Do you still want to be like Jesus?

And the little girl swallowed her tears and she took a deep breath and she said

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LITTLE GIRL: No, I don't want to be like Jesus. I ***am*** Jesus (Pause)

And her parents stuck the spear in her side . . . and they left her there to die, and they went to bed. And in the morning they were quite surprised that she wasn't dead . . . so they took her down off the cross and they buried her alive in a little coffin with just enough air to live for three days . . . and the last voices she heard were her foster parents above, calling out . .

MOM OR DAD: Well, if you're Jesus, you'll rise again in three days, won't you?

And the little girl thought about it for a while, then she smiled to herself and she whispered

LITTLE GIRL: Exactly. Exactly *(Pause)*

And she waited. And she waited. And she waited.

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CLOSING

I'll leave you with one question . . . one you must answer for yourself: Who is culpable? Katurian, Michael, their parents, or society? These are the stories from The Pillowman

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AWARD HISTORY

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